skills—a mixture of aggression and emotion—to connect with voters. Though Reddy wears a certain pugnacity on his sleeve, thorough homework precedes every spoken word. During the poll campaign, charges levelled against the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) government were all investigated beforehand. On learning that KCR's son, minister K.T. Rama Rao, had allegedly flouted regulations to develop a farmhouse, Reddy had a drone flown over it to probe the matter. "His youth and dynamism are his strengths," says P.L. Visveshwar Rao, vice-president, Telangana Jana Samithi. Associates say Reddy is accommodative and has a natural ability to lead from the front.

On his first day in office on December 8, a long line of citizens filed past Reddy at Praja Bhavan, handing him petitions. Slated to be a regular affair, Reddy will be present at what is named *Praja Vani* (people's voice) twice a week and, in his absence, will depute ministers. The *praja vani* system will enable Reddy to hear citizens' problems in detail before introducing changes. There are also plans to hold *praja vanis* in all districts to develop a feedback mechanism. It is something close to Reddy's heart: though even-tempered, he has very little patience with any form of injustice and is ready to go the extra mile in redressing it.

At his first official meeting on December 8, Reddy took stock of the power sector. He had led protests against alleged irregularities in purchase agreements between the state and private energy firms during the BRS regime. "Several sectors have collapsed; the state is in a financial mess. Priority areas should be employment, education and democratic functioning," adds Rao.

On December 9, in keeping with the Congress's pledge of Six Guarantees, Reddy inaugurated free bus rides for women and girls across the state to promote their socio-economic mobility (part of the Mahalakshmi guarantee) and raised the cover under the Rajiv Aarogyasri health insurance scheme from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 10 lakh (part of Cheyutha). That it coincided with the 78th birthday of Sonia Gandhi, who with Rahul and Priyanka attended the swearing-in ceremony, was a welcome happenstance.


ANI

THE LOOMING HURDLES

SIX GUARANTEES
Implementing some of the six guarantees within 100 days, as promised, may prove to be a Herculean task in the midst of the severe cash crunch facing Telangana. The six guarantees entail a massive expense of over Rs 70,000 crore

HIGH DEBT BURDEN
Borrowings by the KCR government imposed an interest burden of Rs 22,407 crore on the government in 2023-24. Telangana's debt burden is nearly Rs 5.50 lakh crore. Plus, the state has generated only 46 per cent of the 2.16 lakh crore revenue target for 2022-23

POWER, IRRIGATION
Reddy has directed preparation of white papers on power, irrigation to expose alleged corruption. Electricity distribution firms have accumulated losses of Rs 50,275 crore and debts of Rs 80,000 crore. The Kaleshwaram Irrigation Scheme involved investment of over Rs 80,000 crore of funds